

[Lesson 32](#): “To Seal the Testimony” (See L32 [Study Guide](#))

**Purpose:** To help us learn about the martyrdom of the Prophet Joseph Smith and to strengthen our testimonies of his calling as a prophet of God.

**1. The Prophet Joseph Smith sealed his testimony with his blood.**

“... the Saints prospered for a few years in Nauvoo. The Church and the city grew rapidly, work on the temple progressed, and the Prophet Joseph Smith received many revelations. However, during 1843 and 1844, animosity against the Church increased. Enemies both inside and outside the Church began trying to destroy it. This opposition climaxed on 27 June 1844.” (*Lesson Manual*, 183-184)

Read “[The Martyrdom](#),” from *Our Heritage*, 62-63.

- D&C 135:4-5. John Taylor wrote section 135.
- D&C 135:1-2. †1. Elder Willard Richards
- D&C 135:6.

What are your feelings as you think about the sacrifice Joseph and Hyrum made for their testimonies?

“... Before Joseph Smith Sr. died, he gave the Prophet a blessing and told him: ‘You shall even live to finish your work.... You shall live to lay out the plan of all the work which God has given you to do.’” (quoted in Lucy Mack Smith, *History of Joseph Smith*, ed. Preston Nibley [1958], 309-10)

†2. Wilford Woodruff

From what you know about the Prophet Joseph Smith’s life, what impresses you most about him?

**2. The Prophet Joseph Smith did more for the salvation of men in this world than anyone except Jesus.**

- D&C 135:3.

In what ways did Joseph Smith do “more, save Jesus only, for the salvation of men in this world, than any other man that ever lived in it”? †3. President Brigham Young †4. Lenet H. Read

*Truths about the Godhead*

*The authority of the priesthood*

*Truths about our origin and relationship to God*

How is knowing that you are literally a child of God, a blessing in your life?

*Truths about the plan of salvation*

*The building of temples and the performances of temple ordinances*

*Other contributions*

*Scriptures:*

Elder Bruce R. McConkie: The Prophet Joseph Smith “has given to our present world more holy scripture than any single prophet who ever lived.” (“[Joseph Smith—The Mighty Prophet of the Restoration](#),” Ensign, May 1976, 95)

Elder Gordon B. Hinckley: Joseph Smith “translated and published the Book of Mormon, a volume of 522 pages which has since been retranslated into [many] languages and which is accepted by millions across the earth as the word of God. The revelations he received and other writings he produced are likewise scripture to these millions. The total in book pages constitutes the equivalent of almost the entire Old Testament of the Bible, and it all came through one man in the space of a few years.” (“[Joseph the Seer](#),” Ensign, May 1977, 65)

†5. Stephen L. Richards †6. Josiah Quincy (former mayor of Boston) †7. Ted L. Gibbons

Next Week: L33: President Brigham Young Leads the Saints; See L33 [Class Member Study Guide](#).

(You can download a free LDS Institute manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#).) † •

†1. **Elder Willard Richards:** “A shower of musket balls were thrown up the stairway against the door of the prison in the second story, followed by many rapid footsteps....

“... A ball was sent through the door, which passed between us, and showed that our enemies were desperadoes....

“... Joseph Smith, Mr. Taylor and myself sprang back to the front part of the room, and ... Hyrum Smith retreated two-thirds across the chamber directly in front of and facing the door.

“A ball was sent through the door which hit Hyrum on the side of his nose, when he fell backwards, extended at length, without moving his feet.

“From the holes in his [clothing], it appears evident that a ball must have been thrown from without, through the window, which entered his back on the right side, and passing through, lodged against his watch.... At the same instant the ball from the door entered his nose.

“As he struck the floor he exclaimed emphatically, ‘I am a dead man.’ Joseph looked towards him and responded, ‘Oh, dear brother Hyrum!’ and opening the door two or three inches with his left hand, discharged one barrel of a six shooter (pistol) at random in the entry.... A ball [from the musket of one of the mob] grazed Hyrum’s breast, and entering his throat passed into his head, while other muskets were aimed at him and some balls hit him.

“Joseph continued snapping his revolver round the casing of the door into the space as before ..., while Mr. Taylor with a walking stick stood by his side and knocked down the bayonets and muskets which were constantly discharging through the doorway....

“When the revolver failed, we had no more firearms, and expected an immediate rush of the mob, and the doorway full of muskets, half way in the room, and no hope but instant death from within.

“Mr. Taylor rushed into the window, which is some fifteen or twenty feet from the ground. When his body was nearly on a balance, a ball from the door within entered his leg, and a ball from without struck his watch ... in his vest pocket near the left breast,... the force of which ball threw him back on the floor, and he rolled under the bed which stood by his side....

“Joseph attempted, as the last resort, to leap [from] the same window from whence Mr. Taylor fell, when two balls pierced him from the door, and one entered his right breast from without, and he fell outward, exclaiming, ‘Oh Lord, my God!’ ... He fell on his left side a dead man.” (*History of the Church*, 6:619-20)

“Elder John Taylor was shot four times but recovered from his wounds. In fulfillment of a prophecy that the Prophet had made more than a year before, Elder Willard Richards received no wounds. Elder Richards recalled that in this prophecy, the Prophet had told him that “the time would come that the balls would fly around him like hail, and he should see his friends fall on the right and on the left, but that

there should not be a hole in his garment.” (*History of the Church*, 6:619)

†2. **Wilford Woodruff:** “Joseph Smith was what he professed to be, a prophet of God, a seer and revelator. He laid the foundation of this Church and kingdom, and lived long enough to deliver the keys of the kingdom to the Elders of Israel, unto the Twelve Apostles. He spent the last winter of his life, some three or four months, with the Quorum of the Twelve, teaching them. It was not merely a few hours ministering to them the ordinances of the Gospel; but he spent day after day, week after week and month after month, teaching them and a few others the things of the kingdom of God. Said he, during that period, ‘I now rejoice. I have lived until I have seen this burden, which has rested on my shoulders, rolled on to the shoulders of other men; now the keys of the kingdom are planted on the earth to be taken away no more for ever.’ But until he had done this, they remained with him; and had he been taken away they would have had to be restored by messengers of heaven. But he lived until every key, power and principle of the holy Priesthood was sealed on the Twelve and on President Young, as their President. He told us that he was going away to leave us, going away to rest. Said, he, ‘You have to round up your shoulders to bear up the kingdom. No matter what becomes of me. I have desired to see that Temple built, but I shall not live to see it. You will; you are called upon to bear off this kingdom.’ This language was plain enough but we did not understand it any more than the disciples of Jesus when he told them he was going away, and that if he went not the Comforter would not come. It was just so with Joseph. He said this time after time to the Twelve and to the Female Relief Societies and in his public discourses; but none of [sic] seemed to understand that he was going to seal his testimony with his blood, but so it was.” (*History of the Church*, 13:164)

### Recommended reading:

1. Elder Bruce R. McConkie, “[Joseph Smith—The Mighty Prophet of the Restoration](#),” *Ensign*, May 1976.
2. Marvin K. Gardner, “[Joseph Smith, Prophet of the Restoration](#),” *Ensign*, June 1994.
3. Elder Henry B. Eyring, “[An Enduring Testimony of the Mission of the Prophet Joseph](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 2003.

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†3. **Brigham Young:** “What is the nature and beauty of Joseph’s mission? You know that I am one of his Apostles. When I first heard him preach, he brought heaven and earth together; and all the priests of the day could not tell me anything correct about heaven, hell, God, angels, or devils: they were as blind as Egyptian darkness. When I saw Joseph Smith, he took heaven, figuratively speaking, and brought it down to earth; and he took the earth, brought it up, and opened up, in plainness and simplicity, the things of God; and that is the beauty of his mission.” (*Journal of Discourses*, 5:332)

†4. **Lenet H. Read:** “Was the coming forth of the Book of Mormon on the Feast of Trumpets coincidental? Latter-day Saints who know about these events do not think so. Scriptural and prophetic truth is often manifest through fulfillment. The golden plates were delivered to the young Prophet Joseph Smith early in the morning of 22 September 1827. The Feast of Trumpets, with prayers pleading for God’s remembrance of his still-exiled people, had begun at sundown the previous evening. The services continued that morning, with a worldwide sounding of the ram’s horn. Unbeknown to Judah, all that those horns represented was now to be fulfilled. For on that day, God remembered His people and set in motion His plan to regather them. On that day, God’s final harvest began. On that day, new revelation was granted which would bring a return to renewed covenants. From that day onward, Israel would be called to repentance in preparation for Christ’s return and reign. The Book of Mormon exists to serve these ends. Today, Moroni’s image trumpets from temple spires around the world a final call to awaken, repent, and prepare.” (“[The Golden Plates and the Feast of Trumpets](#),” *Ensign*, Jan. 2000.)

†5. **Stephen L. Richards:** “And then the cause that he established—could it have endured and prospered so well without the martyrdom? Of course, the answer to this must be conjectural, but it has seemed to me that the spirit of sacrifice, which is elemental in our religious philosophy, and fundamental in the success and triumph of the cause, would never have been so well established without this supreme sacrifice of the founder. . . . Strange that those men who took their lives could not have foreseen that this would be the case, and that there is no sealing of testimony so efficacious as that with blood, and that there is nothing more precious and inspirational to give to a cause than a life. They were blind indeed.” (“Joseph Smith, Prophet-Martyr,” Annual Joseph Smith Memorial Sermons, Dec. 7, 1952, LDS Institute of Religion, Logan, Utah, vol. 1, p. 103. See Ted L. Gibbons D&C [Lesson #32](#) online.)

†6. **Josiah Quincy (former mayor of Boston):** “It is by no means improbable that some future textbook, for the use of generations yet unborn, will contain a question something like this: What historical American of the nineteenth century has exerted the most powerful influence upon the destinies of his countrymen? And it is by no means impossible that the answer to the interrogatory may be thus written: Joseph Smith, the ‘Mormon’ Prophet. And the reply, absurd as it doubtless seems to most men now living, may be an obvious commonplace to their descendants. History deals in surprises and paradoxes quite as startling as this. The man who established a religion in this age of free debate, who was and is today accepted by hundreds of thousands as a direct emissary from the Most High – such a rare human being is not to be disposed of by pelting his memory with unsavory epithets.” (quoted by B. H. Roberts, in *Joseph Smith, The Prophet Teacher*, 8-9)

†7. **Ted L. Gibbons:** “This might be an appropriate week to write your feelings about Joseph Smith and how he has influenced your life. Perhaps one family home evening could be devoted to a discussion of this man and his mission. Certainly your children should know how you feel about Joseph Smith and his work. I hope they have heard your testimony frequently.” (Ted L. Gibbons, D&C [Lesson #32](#) online.)

#### Recommended media:

1. Video: “[Joseph Smith—Prophet of the Restoration](#),” (13:09). This review of the Prophet Joseph Smith’s ministry shows that he has “done more, save Jesus only, for the salvation of men in this world (D&C 135).”
2. Video: Elder Dallin H. Oaks, “[Those Who Knew Joseph Best](#),” (0:50).
3. Elder Jeffrey C. Holland, “[Testimony of the Book of Mormon](#),” (4:39).

#### Further recommended reading:

1. Lenet H. Read, “[The Golden Plates and the Feast of Trumpets](#),” *Ensign*, Jan. 2000, presents a prophecy of Joseph Smith and the plates of gold. See also <http://scriptureslenethread.blogspot.com/p/doctrine-covenants.html>. (Click on Lesson 32.)
2. Nancy Jensen, D&C [Lesson #32](#) online presents some very fine enrichment material and links.
3. William C. Beardall, D&C [Lesson 32](#), online presents a fine outline of events.
4. Ted L. Gibbons, D&C [Lesson #32](#) online.
5. *Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325*, Section 135: Read [Historical Background](#); [135:2](#); and [135:3](#).

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